

Chapter 94 - Residence

Here, Ning Fuyi had no idea where Su Mo had gone. Feeling disheartened, she returned to town and found Nine Infant and Han Ya, who had set up camp at the town's largest Peace Inn.

When she found them, they were downstairs playing mahjong¹ with two strangers, the battle fierce enough to block out the sun and moon.

"Two bamboo!"

"I win!" Han Ya jumped up excitedly, laughing as she raked in the chips on the table. "Pure suit²! Hand it over!"

Ning Fuyi watched their cheerful appearance, crossed her arms, and leaned against the door frame, her gaze distant as she looked at the two of them, causing both their backs to break out in cold sweat.

They both looked up. Han Ya was so startled that she dropped the chips in her hands, hurriedly pulled her hands back to stand at attention, her eyes darting around nervously.

Ning Fuyi's expression was very poor, so even Nine Infant didn't say anything more. She smiled awkwardly, said a few words to those two people, then pulled Han Ya out.

"Master, how did it go?" Han Ya asked, looking up.

"How do you think it went? Look at her expression—she obviously hit wall after wall." Nine Infant reached out to touch Ning Fuyi's face, but Ning Fuyi tilted her head to avoid it.

"Yes, this mortal world's Chu Qingqiu is even harder to deal with than the one in heaven." Although Ning Fuyi hadn't suffered any physical hardship, she was mentally and physically exhausted. "Is there a bed? I need to lie down for a while."

Nine Infant and Han Ya exchanged glances and led her back to the room they had rented. Although the inn in this town wasn't particularly luxurious, it was small but complete, much better than the place where Su Mo slept—like heaven and earth in comparison.

However, lying on the bed with soft bedding, Ning Fuyi felt uncomfortable all over. She sat up cross-legged and sighed heavily.

"Master is so tired, her face has gone pale." Han Ya quickly sat on the bed and began massaging Ning Fuyi's shoulders.

"It's not exactly tiredness." Ning Fuyi frowned, her phoenix eyes full of confusion. "It's that she won't let me get close to her at all."

So she told them about Su Mo's strange behavior, then asked Nine Infant: "I asked you two to help investigate Su Mo's past. Do you have any leads?"

Nine Infant pointed at Han Ya with a smile: "I'm not good at socializing with people, but there are leads. You'll have to ask her."

Upon hearing this, Han Ya jumped off the bed and rather proudly pulled out a booklet, opening it and pulling it apart with both hands like snowflakes of paper: "Master, rest assured! With me, Han Ya, here, there's nothing I can't find out! Look, from her birth until now, every detail is recorded in this booklet!"

"However, there are many rumors mixed in, so the truth is uncertain." Han Ya said, shaking her braids.

Finally, there was some good news in these two days. Ning Fuyi gratefully took the booklet and began reading rapidly.

The more she read, the deeper the furrows between her brows became.

Previously, when she was at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she had read mortal storybooks and thought those mortals' experiences were truly tragic. But now, looking at Su Mo's life in her hands, she suddenly felt those storybooks were nothing in comparison.

"Born with defects, unable to hear clearly. Also contracted a serious illness in her childhood, with no cure found after long treatment. Later, a Taoist gave guidance, saying she was born with dark evil³ and needed to live in seclusion to suppress the evil aura, and could only survive past her coming-of-age by taking spiritual pills to sustain her life."

Ning Fuyi read on, almost crushing the booklet in her hands. She suppressed her anger and looked up, unable to read anymore. Finally, Nine Infant spoke to finish the story.

"Her parents originally ran a medicine shop, specializing in herbal medicine. The family had no farmland, but for her sake, they had to close the medicine shop and move out of the city, making a living by gathering herbs daily to sell. However, the spiritual pills sold by that Taoist were extremely expensive, and her parents simply couldn't afford them."

"Fortunately, her father Su Heng had taken the imperial examinations as a village nominee in his youth and had met the county magistrate of Jing County, Qin Feng, in the capital. Relying on this old friendship, he borrowed enough gold and silver to buy the spiritual pills, promising to repay monthly for the next twenty years. Only then did he manage to save Su Mo's life."

"But heaven is unpredictable. One day, when the couple crossed these mountains to gather herbs in even more remote mountain forests, they unfortunately encountered a white-browed hanging-eyed tiger⁴ and tragically died in the tiger's mouth. From then on, only Su Mo remained in the world." Nine Infant said with regret.

Ning Fuyi's gaze fell on the light and shadow on the opposite wall, staring until her eyes hurt, then closed them.

She wasn't angry at others—she was angry at the heartless Heavenly Dao. Chu Qingqiu had clearly died eliminating demons, not as someone utterly evil. No matter what, she was a hero of heaven and earth. Now that her soul had finally managed to reincarnate, why did her soul have to suffer such tribulations?

"So she labors daily in such poverty, all for this?"

"Exactly." Nine Infant nodded, her expression growing sympathetic. "When Su Heng and his wife died, she was only in her early teens⁵. The debt wasn't fully repaid, so from then on, she alone shouldered this burden, continuing until now."

"Although few people know about Su Mo's situation, the magistrate's family is well-known to all. Magistrate Qin Feng has a son named Qin Xiaoran who somehow developed feelings for Su Mo. This person has been dissolute and unlearned since childhood, not a proper young gentleman at all. His constant harassment of Su Mo is also a topic of discussion in town."

"The common people all say..."

"Say what?" Ning Fuyi's expression grew even more stern.

"They say this Su Mo is a demon woman who cast a spell⁶ on Young Master Qin, which is why Qin Xiaoran treats her so specially."

As soon as Nine Infant finished speaking, the bed post in Ning Fuyi's hand developed a crack: "How outrageous!"

"It's already difficult enough for an orphaned girl to survive and repay debts, yet she still suffers such gossip. Who is wagging their tongues? This venerable one will tear their mouths apart!"

Seeing that she was truly angry, Nine Infant quickly stepped forward to stop her, raising her hand to repair the bed post, shaking her head: "Since ancient times, people's mouths have never been idle. They love to spread rumors and gossip. If you want to argue with them, you probably couldn't kill them all in a lifetime."

"The most important thing now is Su Mo."

Ning Fuyi pressed her red lips into a tight line and said in a low voice: "I know."

"From the moment I left her, I felt uneasy. Now it seems the one who made her so defensive and fearful is probably that Qin Xiaoran." Ning Fuyi stood up and headed for the door.

"I have to go back and check."

This time both Nine Infant and Han Ya followed at her sides. The three of them used invisibility techniques and flew on swords at full speed. In less than a moment, they returned to the small house at the foot of the mountain. Ning Fuyi landed and searched all three rooms but found no trace of Chu Qingqiu.

Her heart immediately sounded alarm bells. Looking around, she found that other things were still there, but only the basket for storing herbs from the corner was missing, so she knew where Su Mo had gone.

A veil had somehow fallen on the ground. Ning Fuyi bent down to pick it up.

"Han Ya, how many medicine shops are there in town?" she asked urgently.

"There are many medicine shops, but the largest is only one, right near the Peace Inn..." Before Han Ya could finish speaking, Ning Fuyi's body had already soared into the clouds. Han Ya and Nine Infant exchanged glances and could only turn to follow.

Ahead of them, black clothes rustled, the dark hem gleaming in the sunlight. Ning Fuyi's speed was terrifying. Despite their best efforts to catch up, the two couldn't keep pace. When they hurried through the crowd to reach the medicine shop, they found Ning Fuyi already standing under the eaves with her hands at her sides, her expression grim.

"How is it?" Nine Infant asked, wiping away sweat.

"The shopkeeper said Su Mo came earlier, sold the herbs she'd gathered over the past few days, and has already left." She spoke, her phoenix eyes turning to Nine Infant. "Nine Infant, I'm afraid I must ask another favor of you today."

Upon hearing this, Nine Infant stepped back, putting her hands up defensively as she looked at her warily: "I won't."

"Please." Ning Fuyi said the words naturally, as if asking for favors came easily to her.

"Demon Venerable, I am a divine beast—a divine beast, do you understand? I'm not a dog. You want me to go sniff around?" Nine Infant's black hair at her forehead stood up. "Why don't you have White Lin do the sniffing?"

"White Lin gets too excited when it sees its master. Once I let it out, I can't control it, and I'm afraid it might frighten Su Mo badly." Ning Fuyi stepped down and pulled at her sleeve. "Nine Infant, I'm very worried about her."

Nine Infant looked at Ning Fuyi's fingers, which had turned white from gripping, and irritably brushed her hand away: "Fine, fine, I'll look for her. Do you have any personal items of hers?"

Ning Fuyi raised her hand and gave her the veil she had just picked up. Nine Infant shook out the veil, then put it away and closed her eyes. The red mark on her forehead brightened imperceptibly.

"Found her. She's in town." Nine Infant said, turning around and striding toward the deeper part of town.

Ning Fuyi's heart didn't know whether to relax or hang high with worry. She closely followed Nine Infant's steps. In no time, the three of them stopped in front of a residence's gate.

Compared to other common dwellings in this town, this residence was located in a secluded area. The main gate faced the stone-paved long street. The door was made of red wood with lacquer, and two jujube trees stood on either side of the entrance, lush and green, reaching toward the sky. This residence was clearly a separate villa. Although it couldn't compare to truly luxurious places, it was uniquely extravagant in this town.

How could Su Mo be here? Ning Fuyi looked up at the plaque and found it bore the characters "Qin Residence," immediately feeling worry rise in her heart.

Su Mo had just sold her herbs and gotten some silver coins. Her coming to the Qin residence villa now should be to repay debts. But although this courtyard looked peaceful and pleasant, the red wooden door was so red it looked like blood, making one feel uncomfortable.

"Let's go." Ning Fuyi said in a deep voice. She didn't sneak in invisibly, but knocked on the gate as a person. When two doorkeeper servants came to inquire, she turned around and with two hand chops, knocked both men to the ground.

"Han Ya, Nine Infant, wait outside. Don't come in unless I say so." After speaking, she stepped across the threshold and closed the door behind her.

The ancient bronze ring, covered with scratches, clanged several times, particularly crisp in the quiet long street. Nine Infant and Han Ya exchanged glances and turned to hide.

The courtyard revealed signs of age everywhere. Moss covered the artificial mountain. Although one could tell someone cleaned it daily, it still couldn't remove the overwhelming sense of decay.

As soon as Ning Fuyi entered, she felt a cold wind, but she paid it no attention and strode toward where she sensed human presence.

The residence was large but had few servants. No one stopped Ning Fuyi along the way, so she easily walked into the inner courtyard. But at this moment, she heard several piercing screams.

Whose voice was that if not Su Mo's? Ning Fuyi's heart nearly leaped out of her throat, but her body moved even faster than her heart. In the blink of an eye, she was standing at the door of the room from which the screaming came.

She had never cared much for proper etiquette between immortals and mortals, and now she had even less time to think about such things. Her palm, mixed with air currents, slapped against the door, sending both door and frame crashing into the room with a thunderous sound, completely exposing the scene inside.

She saw a woman in a green shirt fallen to the ground, cowering in a corner and crying out desperately, her thin body trembling violently in a way that made one's heart clench. Facing her stood a man holding a silver note⁷ and pulling at Su Mo. He had been startled by the suddenly flying door and staggered back, turning to glare angrily.

Seeing Su Mo in such a state, Ning Fuyi felt her heart ache while rage burned within her. Her body instantly became a shadow as she lifted her foot and kicked the man in the chest.

Footnotes:

- ¹ **Mahjong (麻雀牌)** - A traditional Chinese tile-based game commonly played for entertainment and sometimes gambling.
- ² **Pure suit (清一色)** - A winning hand in mahjong where all tiles are from the same suit.
- ³ **Dark evil (阴邪)** - In Chinese folklore, refers to negative spiritual energy or supernatural malevolence that some people are believed to be born with.
- ⁴ **White-browed hanging-eyed tiger (白额吊睛虎)** - A specific description of a tiger with distinctive white markings on its forehead and prominent eyes, often used in classical Chinese literature.
- ⁵ **Early teens (豆蔻之年)** - Literally "cardamom years," a classical Chinese expression referring to a girl around 13-14 years old.
- ⁶ **Cast a spell (降头)** - Refers to a type of Southeast Asian black magic or curse, believed to control someone's mind or emotions.
- ⁷ **Silver note (银票)** - A historical form of paper money or promissory note used in ancient China, backed by silver.